continuous belt of megalithic structures, mostly cisttombs. Many of these have been removed by agriculturists, but some hundreds still survive in intermittent patches.[41]

Reading this description it is apparent that, like Maski, this was marked by habitational debris packed with plenty of potsherds, and with a cemetery area of multiple burials alongside megalithic structures. The royal rescript was meant for this iron-using culture marked by multiple megaliths.[42] As at Maski, the inscribed rock is not at the habitation site but towards its periphery. This would thus have been a place that Isila's inhabitants regularly passed and possibly visited, especially since behind this rock water was available through a seasonal watercourse.[43] A couple of millennia later, washing this boulder (then known as 'akshara gundu', or letter rock) with water was believed to endow it with usable medicinal virtues, which leads logically to the supposition that the superstition may have persisted down to the later period from a time after the Mauryan. What has also survived some distance south-east of the Brahmagiri boulder, up the hill, is a small apsidal structure made of bricks. The ruins revealed a structure made of large bricks (1'5" x 9" x 3–3½") which were thought to be indicative of a fairly early time, although no evidence which would help provide a secure date was found.[44] If this was indeed a Buddhist chaitya or temple, as is surmised, it would mean that the imprint of Buddhism at Brahmagiri went beyond the Buddhist-inspired message of the monarch.

Moving ahead of Brahmagiri, the question arises why Isila's administration decided to get the very same edict inscribed on a rocky knoll just a kilometre or so distant. This falls within the modern limit of Siddapura village and so is known as Ashoka's Siddapura edict. But in the third century BCE the town community of Isila would have been the target audience for the message—the same citizen body that will have imbibed the Brahmagiri message. The oddness of this near duplication cannot be missed, nor the mystery of why such proximity seemed desirable in a context where boulders of a sufficient size for engravings were not remotely